

Chapter 40: He Came Back Different

Jenny didn't sleep well.

Not because she was waiting.

She refused to call it that.

But her phone stayed too close to her pillow.

And every sound outside her window felt louder than it should have.

Morning came too fast.

Or maybe she just didn't notice the night passing.

He arrived just after lunch service started.

Jenny didn't see him enter at first.

She felt him.

That was the only way she could describe it now.

A shift in air.

A change in rhythm.

Like something heavy had returned to the room.

When she finally looked up—

Austin was standing near the entrance.

But he didn't move like before.

He didn't go to table seven.

He didn't go to the counter immediately.

He just stood there.

As if deciding something.

Jenny froze for half a second before forcing herself to move again.

Normal.

Act normal.

"Table seven?" Bao asked quietly.

Jenny nodded.

"Yes."

But her voice didn't sound like hers.

Austin finally walked in.

Not directly to her.

Not directly to the counter.

He stopped halfway.

Like distance itself had become something he was now aware of.

Jenny watched him carefully.

Something was wrong.

Not obvious.

Not dramatic.

But wrong in a way she couldn't ignore anymore.

When he finally approached the counter, Jenny spoke first.

"You're back."

It wasn't a question.

Austin nodded.

"Yes."

A pause.

Then Jenny added,

"You didn't say when you were coming."

"I wasn't sure," he replied.

That made her pause.

"...Not sure about what?"

Austin looked at her.

Not the usual steady observation.

Something more restrained.

Contained.

"I needed to clear something," he said.

Jenny frowned slightly.

"Did you?"

"Yes."

Silence.

Something in his voice had changed.

Not softer.

Not colder.

Just... reduced.

Like parts of him were no longer fully accessible.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Is this about what you said?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

That hesitation was new.

"Yes," he said finally.

That one word made her stomach tighten.

"What kind of talk requires you to disappear for days?" Jenny asked quietly.

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said,

"The kind I couldn't have here."

That landed differently.

Jenny frowned.

"Here?"

"With you," he corrected.

Silence.

That felt heavier than anything before.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"So I'm part of the reason you stopped coming?"

Austin didn't deny it.

That was the problem.

He didn't deny it.

Instead, he said,

"I needed distance to think clearly."

Jenny stiffened slightly.

"And now?"

"I'm still thinking," he said.

"But I'm no longer avoiding it."

That word again.

Avoiding.

Jenny looked away briefly.

Of course she did.

A customer called from a table.

Jenny didn't move immediately.

Bao did instead.

For once, he didn't interrupt.

He just watched.

When she returned, Austin was still there.

Same position.

But not the same presence.

Something had shifted between them.

And it wasn't going back.

Jenny lowered her voice.

"You said you'd talk."

"I am talking," Austin said.

Jenny shook her head slightly.

"No."

A pause.

"This isn't talking. This is... distance with words."

That made him stop for a second.

Not defensive.

Just reflective.

Then—

"Maybe that's what I needed," he admitted.

Jenny frowned.

"You needed distance from me?"

A pause.

Then carefully—

"I needed to understand what happens to me when I don't have control over how I feel."

That sentence hit differently.

Too honest.

Too exposed.

Too unfamiliar coming from him.

Jenny studied him.

"You sound different."

"I am different," he said.

That was the first time he said it so directly.

No filtering.

No softness.

Just fact.

Jenny's voice lowered.

"In what way?"

Austin hesitated again.

Longer this time.

Then—

"I'm not trying to make this easier anymore."

Silence.

That landed heavily.

Jenny blinked.

"...Easier for who?"

A pause.

Then quietly—

"For either of us."

That made something in her chest tighten.

"You were trying to make it easy before?" she asked.

Austin looked at her.

"I was trying to make it stable."

Jenny frowned.

"And now?"

"I don't think stability is the right goal anymore."

That sentence felt like a shift in gravity.

Jenny didn't like it.

Not at all.

She crossed her arms tighter.

"So what is the goal now?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

And when he did, his voice was quieter.

"Truth."

Silence.

Jenny didn't respond.

Because she didn't know what kind of truth he meant.

Or what it would cost.

A long pause stretched between them.

For the first time since this started...

Jenny didn't feel like she was standing in the center of something growing.

She felt like she was standing at the edge of something about to change shape.

And Austin—

was no longer trying to hold it still.